

JS8FastChat

Installation & First Run

Version 1.75 · Windows 11 and Linux · Guide rev 1.55

Part of JS8MapChat

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This guide covers JS8FastChat only. JS8Map has its own guide, and you should install JS8Map first — section 1 explains why.

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1 Before you start

JS8MapChat is the name for two programs that work together. There is no single program called JS8MapChat and no icon by that name. You launch JS8Map, or JS8FastChat, or both.

Program	What it does	This guide?
JS8FastChat	Operator console for directed messages, queries and group traffic.	Yes.
JS8Map	Live map of the stations you are hearing and the stations hearing you.	No — it has its own guide. Install it first.
JS8Call	The digital mode software itself. JS8FastChat reads from it.	No. Required, and installed before either of ours.

JS8FastChat has its own installer, its own icon and its own window. Once both are running, each carries a button that brings the other to the front.

THE ONE RULE ABOUT LAUNCH ORDER Launch JS8Call first, then JS8Map next, finally JS8FastChat. The FastChat button in JS8Map's callsign popup depends on it. Install order and launch order are different things — install JS8Map first, and launch JS8Map first, every session.

1.1 Install JS8Map first

JS8FastChat shows you who is on the air and who each station is — name, city, state and license class. That information comes from the callsign database, and JS8Map is the program that downloads and builds it. JS8FastChat reads it; it does not create it.

So, on a machine with no JS8Map, JS8FastChat starts and runs, but every station stays an anonymous callsign.

IF YOU ALREADY INSTALLED THEM THE OTHER WAY ROUND No harm done and nothing needs reinstalling. Install JS8Map, run it once and let its setup download the databases, and JS8FastChat will find the data on its next start.

On Linux the installer, if it cannot find JS8Map, you will see a warning, not a refusal — installing FastChat first is a reasonable thing to do, and the installer lets you.

1.2 Which version of JS8Call you are running

JS8FastChat works with both JS8Call 2.x and the newer JS8Call Improved 3.x. You do not need to upgrade JS8Call to use it.

Some functions depend on features that exist only in the Improved 3.x version. On 2.x those controls are switched off rather than left to fail silently, so a greyed-out button is the program telling you your JS8Call cannot do that. It is not a fault in JS8FastChat.

Works on	What you get
Both 2.x and Improved 3.x	The activity console, station tables, filters, searching, and the bulk of the directed message traffic.
Improved 3.x only	Halting transmission from within JS8FastChat. Changing speed from within JS8FastChat. Some of the directed message and query shortcuts.

JS8FastChat carries a setting that tells it which JS8Call you have, and it enables or disables the affected controls to match. It is an API Mode selector offering a 2.x compatible mode or Improved 3.x. Set it after installing, once you know JS8FastChat is talking to JS8Call.

NOTE If you are on 2.x and need to stop a transmission, use JS8Call's own Halt TX button. It works exactly as it always has. Only the shortcut from inside JS8FastChat is unavailable.

1.3 What you need first

- JS8Call installed and working, with a callsign and grid square already set.
- JS8Map installed and run once, so the callsign databases exist. See section 1.1.
- JS8Call's TCP API turned on, listening on port 2442, and set to allow at least 5 connections. Section 1.4 covers this, and it is the single most important setting in this document.
- Your Maidenhead grid square — for example FM05SX.

NOTE JS8FastChat will not connect until JS8Call is running with its API enabled. Installing with JS8Call closed is fine, but expect JS8FastChat to sit disconnected until you start it.

1.4 Turning on the JS8Call API — and the connection limit

In JS8Call, open File → Settings → Reporting and find the API section. Set it up exactly like this:

Setting	Set it to
Enable TCP Server API	Ticked.

Setting	Set it to
Accept TCP Requests	Ticked. Without this, JS8Call ignores questions from JS8FastChat.
TCP Server Hostname	127.0.0.1
TCP Server Port	2442
TCP Max Connections	5 or more. The default of 1 is not enough — see below.

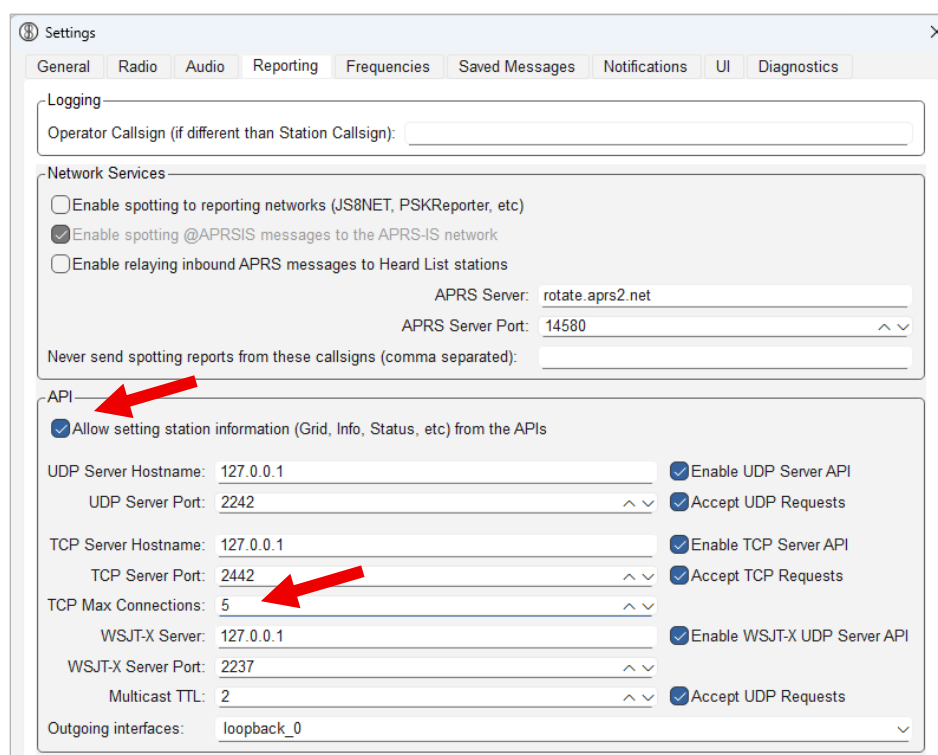


Figure 1 — JS8Call, File → Settings → Reporting. The API section, with the two settings that matter arrowed.

Click OK, then close JS8Call and reopen it. JS8Call only writes its settings to disk when it closes, so a change made without a restart leaves it running on the old setting.

READ THIS EVEN IF YOU SKIP THE REST TCP Max Connections is the number of programs allowed to talk to JS8Call at once, and it ships set to 1. If you are running JS8FastChat, you are running at least two programs against JS8Call, so 1 is guaranteed to be wrong.

JS8Map and JS8FastChat are two separate programs and each needs its own connection. At 1, whichever starts first takes the only slot and the other is refused.

The refusal is silent, and this is what makes it so hard to spot. The refused program still shows activity, because that comes from the shared database rather than from JS8Call, so it looks connected and healthy. What it cannot do is ask JS8Call anything — so the Set Freq and Set Offset boxes sit empty, commands do nothing, and no error is ever displayed. It looks like a fault in JS8FastChat. It is not.

Count everything you run against JS8Call, because each one needs a connection of its own:

- JS8Map — one.
- JS8FastChat — one.
- JS8Spotter, CommStat Improved, or any other companion tool — one each.

Set it to 5 and you have room for JS8Map, JS8FastChat and three other tools. Raise it further if you run more than that.

THE ONE SYMPTOM WORTH MEMORISING Set Freq and Set Offset stay empty while everything else in JS8FastChat looks fine. That is this setting, essentially every time.

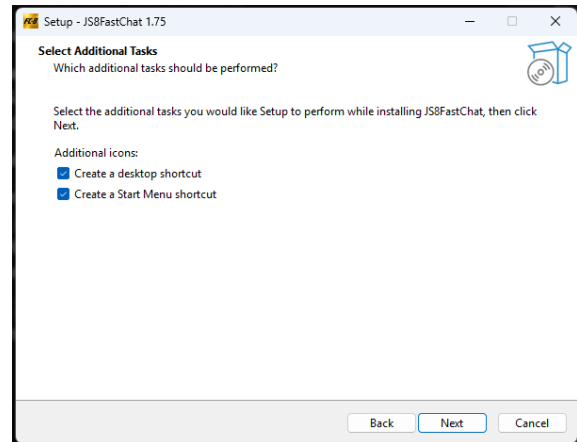
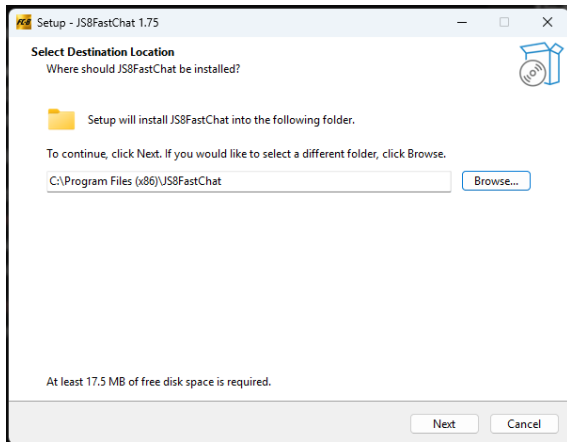
2 Installing on Windows

You receive one file. It is an ordinary Windows installer — double-click it, answer a few questions, done.

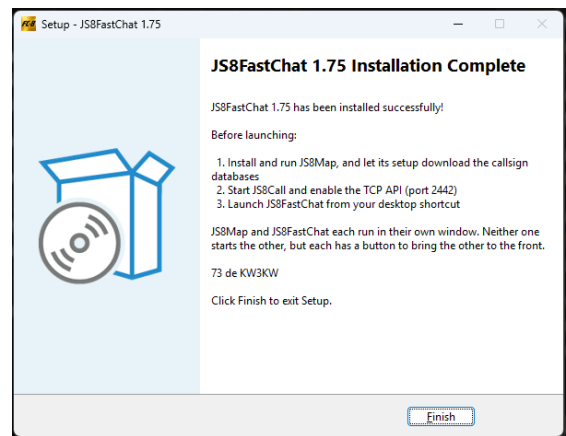
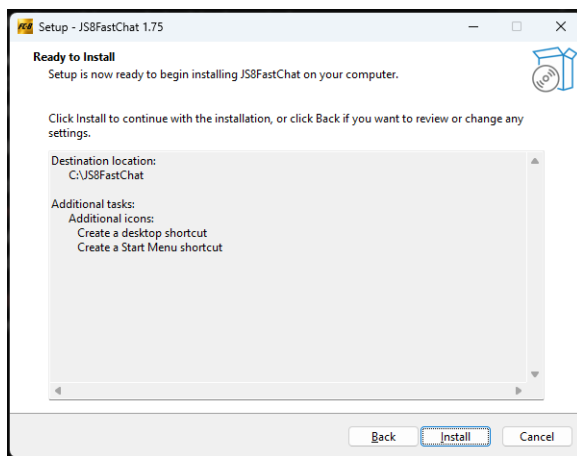
File	What it installs
JS8FastChat_v1.75_Setup.exe	JS8FastChat, and everything it needs.

You do not need Python on Windows. The installer carries everything the program needs. JS8FastChat installs into its own program folder, separate from JS8Map, and that is correct — the two find each other regardless.

The installer offers to create a desktop shortcut and a Start Menu entry. Both are ticked by default. Leave them ticked unless you have a reason not to.



Figures 2 and 3 — The Windows installer. Choose where it goes, then which shortcuts to create.



Figures 4 and 5 — Review before installing, then the finish page with the launch order on it.

When it finishes you have a desktop icon and a menu entry for JS8FastChat. Launch it the same way you launch anything else.

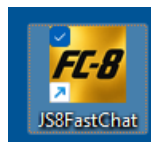


Figure 6 — The JS8FastChat desktop icon on Windows.

2.1 Updating an existing install

Windows upgrades install over the top. Do not uninstall first. Run the new installer and it finds the existing installation and replaces it in place.

IMPORTANT Accept the location the installer offers. Installing JS8FastChat to a different folder orphans the old install and breaks its high-DPI fix, which is keyed to the exact path of the program file — the symptom is a window whose text is suddenly the wrong size. Your settings live outside the program folder and survive an upgrade.

2.2 If nothing seems to happen

On some machines the installer opens behind your other windows instead of in front, and all you see is a new button on the taskbar. Look there before double-clicking again, or press Alt+Tab. Starting it a second time just gives you two copies of the same installer.

The first launch of the program can also take up to a minute with nothing on screen, on a machine that has never run it before. Windows is checking the new file. It is not stuck. Wait before clicking again, for the same reason.

3 Installing on Linux

Linux has a real installer. You are given one compressed file, you unpack it, and you run one command. It installs into your own home folder, so there is no root, no sudo and no package manager involved.

YOU DO NOT NEED PYTHON The Linux package is self-contained. Python, tkinter and every library the program uses are inside it. Nothing needs installing with apt, dnf, pacman or pip. This is true even on a machine that has never had Python on it.

The one requirement is a reasonably modern distribution. The package is built to run on glibc 2.30 and newer, which covers Ubuntu 20.04 and anything more recent, and the equivalent releases of Mint, Debian, Fedora and Arch.

3.1 Installing

You receive one file, named JS8FastChat_v1.75_linux.tar.gz. **Save it in the Downloads folder.**

Now copy and paste this one command in Terminal:

```
cd ~/Downloads
tar -xzf JS8FastChat_v1.75_linux.tar.gz
cd JS8FastChat_v1.75_linux
./install.sh
```

IF IT SAYS PERMISSION DENIED A USB stick formatted FAT32 — which most are — cannot store the execute bit, so install.sh arrives unrunnable if you carried it over on one. Fix it with `chmod +x install.sh` and run the command again. Nothing is wrong with the package.

```
mj@mj-linux1: ~/Downloads/JS8Map_v1.75_linux
mj@mj-linux1:~$ cd ~/Downloads
tar -xzf JS8Map_v1.75_linux.tar.gz
cd JS8Map_v1.75_linux
./install.sh
=====
Installing JS8Map
=====

Installed to: /home/mj/.local/lib/JS8Map
An existing menu entry was saved as js8map.desktop.bak
An existing desktop icon was saved as JS8Map.desktop.bak

-----
Contents of /home/mj/.local/lib/JS8Map
-----
build_canadian_db.py
JS8Map
js8map_admin1.json
js8map_borders.json
js8map_lakes.json
js8map_places.json
js8map.png
leaflet.css
leaflet.js
-----

DONE. JS8Map is installed and all six map files are beside it.

Start it from the applications menu, from the desktop icon,
or by running: /home/mj/.local/lib/JS8Map/JS8Map
mj@mj-linux1:~/Downloads/JS8Map_v1.75_linux$
```

Figure 7 — A successful Linux install. The installer lists everything it wrote, where it wrote it, and how to start the program.

The installer checks that the package is complete before it copies anything, and it prints the contents of every folder it wrote to as its last step. Read that list. It is there so you can see the install landed where it should.

NOTE If JS8Map is not installed, the installer says so and carries on. That is a warning, not a refusal. See section 1.1 for what you lose until JS8Map has run once.

When it finishes you have a desktop icon and a menu entry for JS8FastChat. Launch it the same way you launch anything else.

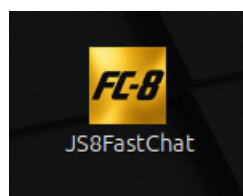


Figure 8 — The JS8FastChat desktop icon on Linux.

3.2 Updating an existing install

Download the new package and run it in the same place the current one is installed. It overwrites the outdated files and leaves your settings intact.

WHY THE LOCATION MATTERS Installing somewhere new does not upgrade anything — it gives you a second, separate install running alongside the first. This is the same rule as on Windows, for the same reason.

3.3 Keeping the two programs in step

JS8Map and JS8FastChat ship as two separate packages so that neither release has to wait on the other. The cost of that choice is that mismatched versions can end up on the same machine.

The symptom is specific and worth knowing: every button that crosses between the two programs stops working, and neither program reports an error. If you see that, the two are out of step — install the matching version of the other one.

TIP The package records a file called `TWIN_shared_resolver.sha256` beside the installed program. If both programs hold the same value there, they match. This is a one-line check rather than an afternoon of guessing.

3.4 If something goes wrong

Start the program from a terminal rather than the desktop icon. A desktop launcher swallows the error message; the terminal shows it.

4 Where things are installed

The program itself is read-only. Everything that changes is kept somewhere else. That separation is why an update never loses your settings.

4.1 Windows

Location	What is kept there
The JS8FastChat program folder	JS8FastChat. Separate from JS8Map, and that is fine. Nothing here needs editing.
%LOCALAPPDATA%\JS8MapChat\	JS8FastChat's settings, and the shared mailbox the two programs pass messages through.
C:\FCC_DB\	The callsign databases. Created and filled by JS8Map; JS8FastChat only reads them.

TIP To reach one of these folders, press Windows+R, type the path from the table and press Enter. You should not normally need to.

4.2 Linux

Location	What is kept there
~/.local/lib/JS8FastChat/	The program and its icon. Nothing here needs editing.
~/.local/share/JS8MapChat/	JS8FastChat's settings.
~/.local/share/JS8MapChat/Shared/	The mailbox JS8Map and JS8FastChat pass messages through.
~/FCC_DB/	The callsign databases. Created and filled by JS8Map; JS8FastChat only reads them.

NOTE JS8FastChat finds the callsign database by asking JS8Map's own configuration where it put it, so it works even if the databases are somewhere unusual. You do not have to point it at anything by hand.

5 First run

JS8FastChat has no download step and no setup wizard. It starts straight into its main window — the databases it needs were already built by JS8Map.

Two things to set on the first run:

1. API Mode. Set it to match your JS8Call — the 2.x compatible mode, or Improved 3.x. See section 1.2.
2. Make sure it is connected to JS8Call as shown below.

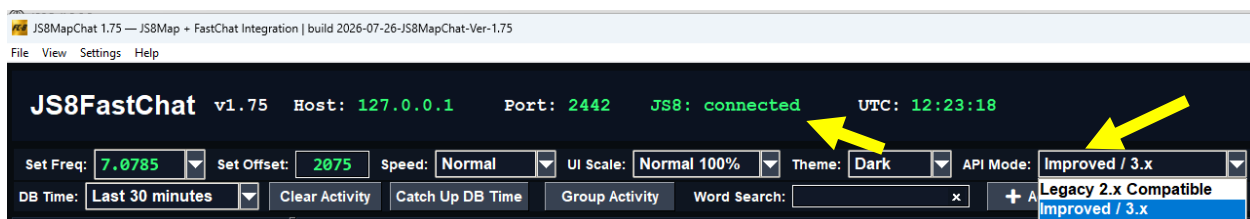


Figure 9 — The top of the JS8FastChat window. Host, port, connection state, and the API Mode selector.

IF THE WINDOW DOES NOT APPEAR Check the taskbar. On some machines it opens behind whatever you were doing rather than in front. Alt+Tab brings it up.

5.1 If the text is too small or too large

There is a UI Scale dropdown in the settings. Use it before you conclude anything is wrong — it is the intended way to fix sizing on a screen the default does not suit, and it applies immediately.

6 How to tell it is working

Work down this list in order. Each line assumes the one above it passed. Have JS8Call running first.

What to look at	What a good result looks like
The connection indicator	Within a few seconds it shows JS8: connected.
The activity list	Stations appear as JS8Call decodes them. On a quiet band this can legitimately sit empty for several minutes.
The station details on any row	Real name, city, state and license class — not just a bare callsign. If everything is bare, the callsign database is missing; see section 1.1.
The Set Freq and Set Offset boxes	They fill in by themselves, in green, matching what JS8Call shows. If they stay empty while everything else works, go straight to section 1.4 — that is the connection limit.
The header button that switches to JS8Map	With JS8Map running, it brings the map window to the front rather than opening a second one.

NOTE Give it time before deciding something is broken. JS8FastChat only knows what JS8Call has decoded, and JS8Call decodes on a fifteen-second cycle. A new install on a quiet evening can sit empty and be entirely healthy.

7 When it does not work

These are the failures new installs actually hit, in rough order of how often they happen.

Symptom	Cause and fix
JS8FastChat looks connected and shows activity, but Set Freq and Set Offset stay empty and commands do nothing.	TCP Max Connections in JS8Call is set to 1 and JS8Map took the only slot. Set it to 5, click OK, then close and reopen JS8Call. See section 1.4. This is the most common fault by a wide margin.
JS8FastChat does not connect to JS8Call at all.	The TCP API is off, or JS8Call is not running. Turn it on in JS8Call's Reporting settings, confirm port 2442, then close and reopen JS8Call so the setting is written to disk.

Symptom	Cause and fix
Stations appear, but every one is a bare callsign with no name or location.	The callsign database has not been built. Install JS8Map, run it once, let its setup finish, then restart JS8FastChat. See section 1.1.
Canadian stations show no details; US ones do.	The Canadian database was skipped during JS8Map's setup. Click Update Canadian DB on JS8Map's main screen. Nothing needs reinstalling.
Nothing appears when you double-click the installer or the program.	Check the taskbar — it may have opened behind your other windows. A first launch can also take up to a minute on a machine that has not run it before.
Buttons that switch to JS8Map do nothing, and neither program reports an error.	The two programs are at mismatched versions. Install the matching version of the other one. On Linux, see section 3.3.
The text is the wrong size after an upgrade on Windows.	The program was installed to a different folder than before, which breaks the high-DPI fix. Reinstall and accept the offered location. See section 2.1.

8 Once you are running

JS8FastChat can key your radio. Everything it sends goes out through JS8Call, and JS8Call's own transmit controls remain in charge — its Halt TX button stops a transmission regardless of what started it.

The two programs coordinate transmission between them, so JS8Map and JS8FastChat will not talk over each other. You do not have to manage that yourself.

If you have not installed JS8Map yet, that is the program that draws the map of who you are hearing and who is hearing you. It has its own installation guide, and JS8FastChat wants it installed — see section 1.1.

The “JS8FastChat Instruction Guide” covers every control in the program. You should not need it to get on the air.